Topic 6 — Foreign Invasions

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Greek Invasion | Alexander's Invasion | Persons Accompanying Alexander | Foreign Invasions | Seleucus Nicator | Indo-Greek Kingdom | Shakas | Parthians | Kushanas | Kanishka | Dress & Art (Gandhara–Mathura)

Sources baked in: NCERT, Arrian/Plutarch, RS Sharma, Junagadh/Nasik epigraphy, Mat / Surkh Kotal sculpture, UPPCS Prelims PYQs 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ — 2023 invader order, Hydaspes vs Beas, Menander/Nagasena, Maues/Rudradaman, Kanishka/Shaka era, Kushan dress, Gandhara–Mathura **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A — static

Books and Writers — Foreign Invasions Age

Book–writer pairs | Greek and companion sources

Book / text	Writer / authority	What it is for
Anabasis (and related *Indica*)	**Arrian**	Alexander's Indian march (draws on Ptolemy and Aristobulus)
Indica (Mauryan India)	**Megasthenes**	Seleucid envoy after ~303 BCE; Chandragupta's court
India–Persia notes	**Ctesias**	Physician to Artaxerxes II
Gymnosophist / march notes	**Onesicritus**	Helmsman-writer with Alexander
Milinda Panha	**Menander (Milinda)** and **Nagasena**	Indo-Greek Buddhist dialogue

- **Megasthenes** did **not** march with Alexander. He comes after the Seleucus treaty.
- *Milinda Panha* also sits in Topics 4 and 8. Monk = **Nagasena**, not Nagarjuna.

Logic: Full campaign teaching stays in the Alexander cards below.

6.1 Greek Invasion

Two layers: Persian satrapy first, then Macedon | papers' "Greeks" = Alexander plus Indo-Greek

- **Cyrus** (died 530 BCE) reaches the Indus fringe in **legend** only. The **satrapy** is **Darius I**, about **518/516 BCE**.
- Darius holds **Gandhara** and **Hindush** (Sindh). Herodotus calls this the **20th** satrapy (out of 28 satrapies). Tribute is remembered as **360 talents of gold dust** (accounting for one-third of total imperial revenue). Contact lasted ~200 years, introduced the **Kharosthi script** (written right-to-left, derived from Aramaic) into NW India, and influenced Mauryan bell-shaped capitals. Behistun, Persepolis, and Naqsh-i-Rustam preserve Darius-age imperial lists and images.
- **Skylax of Caryanda** sails the Indus to the sea. Persepolis and Naqsh-i-Rustam reliefs show Indian delegates.
- **Xerxes** took Indian infantry and archers into the Persian host against the Greeks. Herodotus records this.
- **Ctesias** served as state physician to **Artaxerxes II** and wrote on India–Persia from that court world.
- The NW office kit that stays is **Aramaic**, which feeds **Kharoshthi** (right-to-left). The title that stays is **satrap / kshatrapa**.
- The Macedonian sequel uses the **same NW door**, with a new army.

Year	Macedonian step
334	Granicus
333	Issus
331	**Gaugamela**
330	Persepolis
329–327	Bactria–Sogdiana
326	**India**

- There is no Greek *raj* on the Ganga.
- The 323 vacuum is filled by **Chandragupta** (चंद्रगुप्त).
- Later Bactrian Greeks in India are the **Indo-Greeks**.

> **Logic:** The first imperial foreigners in the NW are the **Persians**. The 2023 “Greeks” still means the Hellenistic wave, not Darius.

6.2 Alexander's Invasion

Born 356 at Pella | king 336 | India 327–325 (~19 months) | year 326

Alexander’s Indian march lasts about **19 months**. The fight year to remember is **326 BCE**. The stop river is the **Beas (Hyphasis)**.

Entry and Taxila (327–326)

- In **327** he crosses the Hindu Kush into the Cophen (Kabul) valley.

- He takes **Massaga** of the Assakenoi.
- He takes the Rock of **Aornos** (Pir-Sar).
- In **326** he crosses the **Indus** (सिंधु).
- **Ambhi / Omphis** of Taxila **submits** and becomes an ally.
- **Abisares** of Kashmir sends gifts and does not fight.

Hydaspes and after

- The Battle of the **Hydaspes** is fought on the **Jhelum** (झेलम) against **Porus**. The full Cause → Course → Result card for that fight sits below in this chapter.
- He then crosses the Acesines (Chenab) and the Hydraotes (Ravi).
- He storms **Sangala** of the **Kathaioi**. This is not Menander's Sagala.
- **Phegeus** warns him of Nanda numbers.
- At the **Hyphasis (Beas)** the army mutinies. **Coenus** speaks for the troops.
- Alexander raises **twelve altars** and turns west.
- Among the **Malloi / Malavas** Alexander is pierced by an arrow.
- The **Oxydrakai** (Kshudrakas) submit.

Return and aftermath

- **Nearchus** sails from the Indus mouth to the Gulf.
- The **Gedrosia** desert march is a slaughter.
- He leaves **Ambhi** as satrap at Taxila and **Porus** over the Hydaspes country.
- **Philip** is a satrap and is later murdered.
- **Peithon** holds the lower Indus.
- **Eudemus** is a leftover officer.
- In **323** Alexander dies at **Babylon**. The Indian posts evaporate.

Why the march matters

- The march gives the first tight Greek *description* of India.
- Northwest satrapies last only a blink.
- Sea and land route knowledge comes via **Nearchus**.
- **Sandrokottos = Chandragupta** is the peg of **William Jones**. Magadha and Buddha dates hang on this.
- The power vacuum is what the **Mauryas** fill.
- The seed of later portrait coins and Gandhara style is planted here.
- Sources are Arrian's *Anabasis* and *Indica*, from Ptolemy and Aristobulus. Also used are Plutarch, Diodorus, Curtius, and Justin.
- There is no Indian royal inscription of the march.

> **Logic:** Hydaspes is the **fight**. Hyphasis is the **stop**. Sangala is not Sagala. The Ganga is a trap.

6.2a Battle of the Hydaspes (326 BCE) — Cause, Course, Result

River: Jhelum (**Hydaspes**) | **Foe:** Porus (Paurava)

Cause: After **Ambhi** submitted at **Taxila** (तक्षशिला), Porus blocked the east bank of the Jhelum. Alexander needed a crossing to push toward the Ganga plain. **Course:** Alexander left **Craterus** visible on the camp bank while he crossed at night in rain. Porus met him with war **elephants**. After hard fighting, Porus was defeated. **Result:** Porus was restored and **enlarged** under Macedonian suzerainty. Alexander founded **Nicaea** and **Bucephala**. The army later **refused** to march past the **Beas (Hyphasis)**.

Massaga (327 BCE) — Cause, Course, Result

People: Assakenoi | **Region:** Swat valley

Cause: The **Assakenoi** blocked Alexander's advance from the Cophen (Kabul) valley into the Punjab approach. Their capital was **Massaga**. **Course:** Alexander besieged **Massaga**. After heavy male losses, Greek writers say the **women took up arms**. Fighting resumed and the city was stormed; tradition remembers a massacre of the town's people. **Result:** The Swat route opened. Alexander could march toward the **Indus** crossings of **326**.

Rock of Aornos (327 BCE) — Cause, Course, Result

Site: Pir-Sar (tradition) | **Fact:** "last natural fortress" before the Indus plain

Cause: Local tribes held a steep rock that controlled the line of march. **Course:** Alexander built a siege mound and scaled the rock in a night assault after encircling the defenders. **Result:** The last major mountain barrier before the **Indus** plain fell. The army could descend toward **Taxila** and **Ambhi**.

Sangala (326 BCE) — Cause, Course, Result

People: Kathaioi | **Trap:** not Menander's **Sagala (Sialkot)**

Cause: After Hydaspes, the **Kathaioi** fortified **Sangala** and resisted Macedonian control east of the Chenab. **Course:** Alexander stormed the city with siege engines after crossing the **Acesines (Chenab)** and **Hydraotes (Ravi)**. **Result:** Sangala was destroyed. This town is **not** Indo-Greek **Sagala** of **Menander (Milinda)**.

Malloi campaign (326 BCE) — Cause, Course, Result

People: Malloi / Malavas | **Fact:** Alexander **wounded**

Cause: The **Malloi** and allied **Oxydrakai (Kshudrakas)** resisted on the lower Indus approach after the eastward push stalled at the **Beas**. **Course:** Alexander led a punishing campaign into their towns. In one assault he was **pierced by an arrow** — his serious Indian wound. **Result:** The **Malloi** were crushed. The **Oxydrakai** submitted. Alexander then turned to the **Indus delta** and **Nearchus**'s fleet.

6.2b Results of Alexander's Indian Campaign

- Alexander **never** fought **Dhana Nanda** and **never** reached Pataliputra. Dhana is the Greek **Agrammes**; his commander is remembered as **Bhaddasala**.
- Macedonian satrapies in India collapsed after his **323 BCE** death.

- Greek writers' **Sandrokottos = Chandragupta Maurya** is the main **chronology peg**.
- The campaign opened the northwest to **Greek reports**, later **Indo-Greek** (इंडो-ग्रीक) rule, and **Gandhara art**.
- Magadhan power filled the vacuum the Macedonians did not hold.
- Standard causes of Alexander's Indian success: **no central power**, a **superior army**, and help from **traitorous Indian rulers** such as Ambhi. "Good administrator" is **not** treated as a cause of that victory.

6.3 Persons Accompanying Alexander

Who was on the road | who was not

- **Aristobulus** is an engineer and writer, an eyewitness behind Arrian. **Ptolemy I** is a general whose memoir also feeds Arrian. He later becomes a Pharaoh. He is **not** an Indian king.
- **Nearchus** is the admiral who sails from the Indus mouth to the Persian Gulf. **Onesicritus** is the helmsman who writes of gymnosophists, the "naked philosophers."
- **Craterus** is a general sent **overland** with veterans. **Coenus** is the voice of the **Beas** mutiny.
- **Seleucus** is an officer on the march, but his Indian war is **after** Alexander. **Hephaestion** is Alexander's intimate and chiliarch. He is on the Indian march. He dies in 324. He is not the Beas story.
- **Callisthenes** is the court historian and Aristotle's kin. He is killed **before** India, in the proskynesis row. **Eudemus** is left in the Punjab as a post-323 leftover.
- **Aristotle** did **not** march to India. He was tutor in Macedon only.
- **Megasthenes** did **not** march to India. He is a Seleucid envoy about **303**, at Chandragupta's court.
- **Deimachus** did **not** march with Alexander. He is the later Seleucid envoy to **Bindusara** (Antiochus's court). Companion writers who **did** come include **Nearchus**, **Onesicritus**, and **Aristobulus**.
- **Kautilya / Chanakya** did **not** march to India. He is on the Mauryan side, not in the Macedonian tent.
- **Ambhi** is the Taxila ally. **Porus** is the Hydaspes foe who becomes a satrap.
- **Kalanos** (Kalyana) is a gymnosophist who *joined* the column and later burnt himself at Pasargadae or Susa. **Dandamis** (Mandanis) is the gymnosophist who **refused** Alexander.
- **Abisares** is the Kashmir chief who sends tribute and does not battle. **Phegeus** is the king who talks of the Nanda host.
- The **Diadochi** come after 323. They are not "companions in Punjab." Named Diadochi are Perdiccas, Ptolemy, Seleucus, Antigonus, Lysimachus, and Cassander. Partitions are dated at Babylon 323 and Triparadisus 321.

> **Logic:** Aristotle, Megasthenes, and Chanakya are **not** on the Indian march. Kalanos is not Dandamis.

6.4 Foreign Invasions

Northwest door — full chronology | 2023 Q23 tests only Greeks → Sakas → Kushans

- The **Achaemenid Persians** open the imperial sequence in the 6th–4th centuries BCE. **Darius I** holds Gandhara and Hindush as the 20th satrapy.
- The **Macedonian Greeks** under **Alexander** enter in **326 BCE**. Their Indian stay is a **Punjab–Sindh** campaign, not a Ganga empire.
- The **Seleucid probe** of **Seleucus Nicator** about **305–303 BCE** ends in treaty with **Chandragupta Maurya**. Magadha stays Indian.
- The **Indo-Greeks** (Bactrian Greeks) push into India from about the **2nd century BCE**. **Demetrius** and **Menander** (मिनांडर) are the headline kings.
- The **Shakas** (Indo-Scythians) follow the Indo-Greeks from about the **1st century BCE**. **Maues** is the first strong name in India. **Rudradaman** is the Junagadh fact.
- The **Parthians** (Pahlavas) hold a **brief** north-west belt in the **1st century CE** between the western Shakas and the rising Kushans. **Gondophares** is the name to remember.
- The **Kushans** (a Yuezhi clan) build the biggest post-Mauryan foreign empire in the **1st–3rd centuries CE**. **Kanishka** is the greatest ruler.
- The textbook memory order is **Greeks → Shakas → Parthians → Kushans**. Many match-list stems drop Parthians and test only **Greeks — Sakas — Kushans**.
- **Vikrama Samvat 57 BCE** is the traditional era of Vikramaditya versus Shakas at Ujjain. It is **not** the Shaka era.
- **Shaka era 78 CE** is the national-calendar era keys. It is usually tied to **Kanishka's** accession tradition.
- Mauryas, Shungas, Satavahanas, and Guptas are **Indian** powers in the gaps. They are not Central Asian invaders.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q23

With reference to the invaders in Ancient India, which one of the following is the correct chronological order?

A. Greeks — Sakas — Kushans B. Greeks — Kushans — Sakas C. Sakas — Greeks — Kushans D. Sakas — Kushans — Greeks

Show answer

Logic: Stem tests relative order only; "Greeks" here means the Hellenistic entry (Alexander + Indo-Greek), not Darius. **Ans: A** — Hellenistic Greeks (Alexander + Indo-Greek) **before** Shakas **before** Kushans. Trap B flips the last two.

> **Logic:** In that trio, "Greeks" = the whole Hellenistic entry, not "only 326."

6.5 Seleucus Nicator

Diadochus | Seleucid founder | Indian file = the Chandragupta treaty

- Seleucus is an infantry officer under Alexander. After 323 he builds the Seleucid realm from Anatolia toward Bactria.
- About **305 BCE** he comes east for Alexander's old satrapies and meets **Chandragupta Maurya**. The war does **not** give him Magadha.
- The **treaty about 303 BCE** is remembered by Appian and Strabo. Seleucus cedes **Arachosia, Gedrosia, and Paropamisadae** — the east Afghan–Baluch–Kabul belt, "west of the Indus" Hindi.
- Chandragupta gives **500 elephants**. Tradition adds a marriage alliance with **Helena**. Seleucus sends **Megasthenes** to Pataliputra.
- Those elephants show up at **Ipsus in 301 BCE**, when Seleucus fights Antigonus.
- *Indica* describes Chandragupta's Pataliputra. This file's fact is that **Seleucus sent** Megasthenes after about 303.
- Later envoy **Deimachus** goes to Bindusara. Ptolemaic envoy **Dionysius** is also named in later lists.
- Greek *Sandrokottos / Androcottus* is Chandragupta. Seleucus is murdered in **281 BCE**. The Indian provinces stay Mauryan.

> **Logic:** Seleucus **lost** the Indian borderlands. He did not sit at Pataliputra.

6.5a Seleucus–Chandragupta War and Treaty (~305–303 BCE)

Cause: After Alexander's death, Seleucus wanted the eastern satrapies. Chandragupta had taken the Nanda throne and pushed into the northwest.

Course: Seleucus marched east but could **not** take Magadha. Fighting ended in negotiation.

Result: Seleucus **ceded Arachosia, Gedrosia, and Paropamisadae**. Chandragupta gave **500 elephants** and probably a marriage alliance (**Helena** tradition). Seleucus sent **Megasthenes** to Pataliputra.

6.6 Indo-Greek Kingdom

Bactrian Greeks in the Punjab–Gandhara | 2nd–1st c. BCE | many kings, few must-score names

Indo-Greek entry into India — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Greco-Bactria broke free of the Seleucids and faced fragmenting NW politics after Alexander's satrapies faded. Independent Bactrian kings pushed south and east for land and trade.

Course: Demetrius I opens the big Indian push about **180 BCE**. Later lines hold Gandhara–Punjab; **Menander (Milinda)** peaks from **Sagala (Sialkot)** and enters Buddhist memory through the *Milinda Panha*.

Result: Portrait die-struck coins, bilingual legends, and Hellenistic seeds for Gandhara art enter India. Indo-Greeks sit **after** Alexander's lifetime and **before** Shakas and Kushans in the invader order.

Framework — how the house opens

- Greco-Bactria breaks from the Seleucids under **Diodotus**, about **250 BCE**.
- **Euthydemus** faces Antiochus III's siege and keeps Bactrian independence.
- About thirty Hellenistic kings rule fragmented NW principalities from the **2nd century BCE** into the early **1st century CE**. Papers do **not** need all thirty names.
- In chronology, these Indo-Greeks sit **after** Alexander's own lifetime and **before** Shakas and Kushans.

Kings — one card each

- **Demetrius I** (about **180 BCE**), son of Euthydemus, makes the first big Greek push into India after Alexander. He conquers southern Afghanistan and parts of Punjab. His famous coin type wears an **elephant-scalp** helmet. He is the Indian-invasion king of the house.
- **Apollodotus I** is often treated as the first king whose power is centred on the Indian side rather than on Bactria. He issues early Indian-side **silver** (रूपक) and holds Gandhara–western Punjab.
- **Agathocles** puts early **Brahmi** (ब्राह्मी) legends on coins. His types include **Sankarshana (Balarama)** and **Vasudeva**.
- **Pantaleon** belongs to the same early bilingual / Vaishnava coin horizon as Agathocles.
- **Eucratides** splits Bactria and fights the Euthydemid line. Indian Greek lines outlive Bactria itself.
- **Menander I (Milinda)** is the greatest Indo-Greek. He rules about the mid-**2nd century BCE** from **Sagala (Sialkot)**. His coin type is **Athena Alkidemos**. The *Milinda Panha* is his debate with the monk **Nagasena**. Tradition remembers him as a Buddhist patron. His reach is remembered from the Kabul valley toward the Ravi and, in some memories, farther east.
- **Agathocleia** is queen and regent with her son **Strato I** after Menander's age.
- **Antialcidas** rules from Taxila tradition and sends the ambassador **Heliodorus** to Sunga Vidisha.
- **Hermaeus** is among the last Indo-Greek names in the **Kabul** belt.
- **Strato II** is among the last in eastern Punjab and is remembered for **lead** coins.

Culture, coins, sites

- The *Yuga Purana* / Gargi tradition has **Yavanas** toward **Pataliputra** (पाटलिपुत्र). That raid is hung on Demetrius or Menander, **not** on Alexander in 326 BCE.
- Heliodorus raises the Besnagar Garuda pillar about **113 BCE**. He calls himself a Bhagavata of **Vasudeva**.
- Coins are the first **portrait, die-struck** money in India. Legends are **Greek plus Kharoshthi**. Sometimes Brahmi appears.
- Metal on the Indian side is silver and copper. **Gold** is the **Kushan** headline under Vima and Kanishka, not under Menander.
- Gandhara Greco-Buddhist sculpture starts from this Hellenistic seed and **peaks under the Kushans**, beside Mathura.
- The end comes when **Shakas** eat the west. **Azes I** takes remaining Greek ground from kings such as **Hippostratos** in numismatic lists.

- Pushyamitra's **Ayodhya** (अयोध्या) inscription is the ashwamedha record. It is not Heliodorus.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q24

Milind Panho is in the form of a dialogue between King Milind and a Buddhist saint. The concerned saint was—

A. Nagarjun B. Nagbhatt C. Nagasena D. Kumaril Bhatt

Show answer

Logic: Stem tests the monk of *Milinda Panha*, not the later Madhyamaka philosopher. **Ans: C — Nagasena.** King = Menander / Milinda. Trap A swaps in **Nagarjuna**.

Logic: Milinda = **Menander**. Nagasena ≠ Nagarjuna. Heliodorus' pillar is **Besnagar**. Pushyamitra's two ashwamedhas are recorded at **Ayodhya**, not Besnagar.

6.7 Shakas

Indo-Scythians from Central Asia | after Indo-Greeks, before Kushans | title kshatrapa / mahakshatrapa

Shaka entry into India — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Scythian / Shaka tribes were pushed west and south when Chinese pressure and steppe wars closed their eastern path. Bactria and the Indo-Greek northwest were already fragmenting.

Course: From about the **1st century BCE**, Shaka horse-nomads enter **Gandhara** and the Indus belt. **Maues / Moga** plants the first strong Indo-Scythian power around **Taxila / Sirkap**. Later lines move into western India as **kshatrapas**.

Result: Indo-Greek rule thins in the west. Chronology for the 2023 invader trio becomes **Greeks → Shakas → Kushans**. Trousers, coats, and boots enter north Indian royal portrait tradition.

- The Indian name **Shaka** means the **Scythians**, Iranian nomadic tribes of the Central Asian steppes.
- The Persian administrative word **kshatrapa** (satrap) becomes their Indian title. A great western ruler takes **mahakshatrapa** (महाक्षत्रप).
- Like later Kushans, Shaka horse-nomads keep **trousers**, coats, and boots in portrait tradition. That northern dress later shapes boot-clad **Surya** images.

Kings — north-west line

- **Maues**, also called **Moga**, is the earliest Indo-Scythian king named in India. He establishes Shaka power in **Gandhara** and around **Taxila**.
- His rule runs on both sides of the Indus, from **Pushkalavati** in the west to **Taxila** in the east. His capital tradition points to **Sirkap**.
- His coins are mostly copper with some silver. Obverse types mix Greek deities with **Shiva** and **Buddha**.

- **Azes I** is the usual successor in numismatic lists. He finishes off remaining Indo-Greek pockets in the Punjab belt.

Kings — Western Kshatrapa houses

- The **Kshaharata** line rules in the western Deccan belt. **Bhumaka** is an early name.
- **Nahapana** is the greatest of the Kshaharata house. His coins appear from **Ajmer** to **Nasik** (नासिक). His capital is **Minnagara**, between Ujjain and Broach.
- Nahapana's son-in-law **Ushavadatta** is viceroy of the southern part and appears in Nasik cave donations.
- **Gautamiputra Satakarni** of the Satavahanas defeats Nahapana. The **Nasik prasasti** of queen **Gautami Balashri** records the victory. Nahapana's silver was restruck in the Jogalthembi hoard type.
- The **Kardamaka** line rules western India from about the 1st century CE. **Chashtana** is the founder named in the **Andau inscription** of 130 CE.
- **Jayadaman** sits between Chashtana and the great grandson in standard genealogies.
- **Rudradaman I** is Chashtana's grandson and the greatest western Shaka. He rules about **130–150 CE** as **mahakshatrapa**.

Rudradaman and the Junagadh inscription — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Western Kshatrapa power needed a Sanskrit public boast after Satavahana pressure and lake failure on the Kathiawar coast. **Rudradaman I** (about **130–150 CE**) ruled as **mahakshatrapa** from **Ujjain** (उज्जैन).

Course: His **Junagadh / Girnar** rock inscription — the first long literary **Sanskrit** prose record in India — narrates the **Sudarshana lake** story: **Pushyagupta** built it under **Chandragupta Maurya**; **Tushaspha** adorned it under **Ashoka** (अशोक); a storm burst the embankment; **Rudradaman repaired it without forced labour**. He also boasts victories over a Satavahana **Satakarni** and the **Yaudheyas**.

Result: The inscription locks Rudradaman as the greatest western Shaka and proves Mauryan–Ashokan–Shaka continuity on one rock. He did **not** claim he founded the lake. Western kshatrapas later last until **Rudrasimha III** falls to **Chandragupta II** (चंद्रगुप्त द्वितीय).

- Kardamaka coinage is mainly **silver** and **potin**. Copper issues are rare.
- Shaka rule in the far northwest fades as **Kushans** take Gandhara.
- **Vikrama Samvat 57 BCE** belongs to the Vikramaditya legend at Ujjain. It must not be confused with **Shaka era 78 CE**, which belongs to the Kushan age.

> **Logic:** Maues is **Shaka**, not Parthian. Junagadh is **Rudradaman**, not Kharavela (Hathigumpha). Nahapana is beaten by **Gautamiputra**, not by Rudradaman.

6.8 Parthians

Pahlavas | brief northwest bridge | between western Shakas and Kushan rise

Parthian bridge in the northwest — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: After Shaka settlement, Indo-Parthian / Pahlava houses filled remaining power gaps in Gandhara–Punjab before the Kushan climax.

Course: Their Indian hold is **short**. The best-known king is **Gondophares** (about **19–45 CE**), remembered in the Kabul–Taxila belt and at **Takht-i-Bahi**.

Result: Parthians sit as a brief bridge between western Shakas and rising Kushans. Do not swap Gondophares with **Maues** (Shaka) or **Kanishka** (Kushan).

- The **Parthians** are called **Pahlavas** in Indian sources.
- Earlier Indo-Parthian names such as **Vonones** appear in coin lists, but **Gondophares** is the must-score Indian fact.
- The site fact for Parthian Buddhism in the NW is **Takht-i-Bahi** near Mardan in Pakistan. It is a famous monastic complex of the period.
- Christian legend places **St Thomas** at Gondophares' court. That is pious tradition, not a royal edict.
- **Kujula Kadphises** of the Kushans displaces Parthian and remaining Greek power in the northwest. After him the Kushan empire grows.

> **Logic:** Gondophares is **Parthian / Pahlava**. He is not Maues (Shaka) and not Kanishka (Kushan). Takht-i-Bahi is the Parthian-period site fact.

6.9 Kushanas

Yuezhi clan from Central Asia | 1st–3rd c. CE | Silk Road empire | last of the 2023 trio

Kushan rise in the northwest — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Chinese pressure and Scythian movements pushed **Yuezhi** clans west into Bactria; after Greeks, Shakas, and Parthians, a new Central Asian house filled the northwest vacuum.

Course: The Kushanas first occupy **Bactria**, then cross the **Hindu Kush** into **Gandhara** and the Punjab. **Kujula Kadphises** unifies clans; **Vima Kadphises** widens gold coinage; **Kanishka** peaks the empire.

Result: At height the line runs from the **Oxus** to the middle **Ganga** (गंगा). Kushans are **last** in the invader trio Greeks → Sakas → Kushans.

- The **Kushanas** were one clan of the **Yuezhi** (Tocharian) nomads of north Central Asia.
- They replaced Greeks, Shakas, and Parthians in the northwest.
- Their empire at its height ran from the **Oxus** to the middle **Ganga**, covering much of Afghanistan, Pakistan, and north India.

Kings — full line (must name each)

- **Kujula Kadphises** is the founder who unifies Yuezhi clans and takes Gandhara–Punjab. His coinage is mainly **copper**.

- **Vima Taktu / Vima Takto** sits in Rabatak genealogy between Kujula and Vima Kadphises in modern readings. Prelims still treat **Vima Kadphises** as the gold-coin headline after Kujula.
- **Vima Kadphises** (Kadphises II) issues the first large **gold** coinage in India on a wide scale. His titles include **Shaonanoshao** (king of kings) and **Sarvalokeshvara**.
- **Kanishka** is the greatest Kushan. The full Kanishka card sits in the next section.
- **Huvishka** continues the imperial gold series and Buddhist–Hindu eclectic coin types after Kanishka.
- **Vasudeva I** is the last great name before the empire fragments. Later minor Kushans hold reduced NW pockets.

Capitals, coins, dress, art

- The main capital is **Purushapura (Peshawar)**. **Mathura** in Uttar Pradesh is the second great Kushan centre inside India.
- Dynastic sanctuaries at **Mat** (near Mathura) and **Surkh Kotal** (Afghanistan) hold royal portrait statues.
- Kushan coins are **gold dinaras** with legends in **Greek**, **Bactrian**, and **Kharoshthi**. Royal portraits are standard.
- Kushan kings wear Central Asian riding dress: long **caftan / quilted coat**, **trousers**, belt, and heavy **boots**. This is the first Indian imperial house systematically shown in trousered dress.
- Kushan patronage creates two great art schools side by side. **Gandhara** sculpture is Greco-Buddhist in the northwest. **Mathura** sculpture uses red sandstone and Indian types. The full Gandhara–Mathura compare sits in the art section below.
- The Kushans are **last** in the 2023 invader trio: Greeks → Sakas → Kushans.

> **Logic:** Kushan gold is the headline under **Vima**, not Menander. Purushapura is Kushan; Sagala is Indo-Greek. Mathura's big foreign layer is Kushan, not Alexander.

6.10 Kanishka

Greatest Kushan | Purushapura | Shaka era 78 CE | Buddhist council | Mat statue

- **Kanishka** is the most famous Kushan ruler. His empire included Afghanistan, Gandhara, Punjab, and much of the Ganga plain.
- Coaching usually pegs his accession to **78 CE**, the start of the **Shaka Samvat** (Shaka era). Some reference books use about **127 CE** for his reign peak. Prelims still want **78 CE** when they say Shaka era.
- Kanishka uses the title **Devaputra** (son of god), mixing Indian, Iranian, and Hellenistic royal ideas. The **Rabatak inscription** from Afghanistan gives his genealogy and names cities **Saketa, Kaushambi, Pataliputra, and Champa — not Shravasti**.
- The Sarnath Buddhist image set up by the monk **Bala** is dated about **81 CE** (year 3 of Kanishka's era).

Dress and royal image

- The headless **Mat** statue near Mathura shows Kanishka standing frontally with a **mace** and a **sword**.
- He wears a long heavy coat, trousers, and oversized **padded boots** — steppe kit kept even in the Indian plains.
- The Brahmi inscription style on such royal images remembers titles like **Maharaja Rajadhiraja Devaputra Kanishka**.
- A parallel dynastic look appears at **Surkh Kotal** in Afghanistan. Coins show the same stiff, frontal, armed king.

Fourth Buddhist Council

- Kanishka convenes the **Fourth Buddhist Council** in **Kashmir** at **Kundalvana / Kundalavana** (tradition places it in the Kashmir valley).
- **Vasumitra** is remembered as president of the council. **Ashvaghosha** writes the *Buddhacharita* (बुद्धचरित) in this age. Court memory also names **Parsva**, **Nagarjuna**, and physician **Charaka** (चरक).
- The school associated with the council is **Sarvastivada** (सर्वास्तिवाद). Mahayana Buddhism grows strongly under Kushan patronage.
- Council-king memory for earlier councils: **Ajatashatru** (अजातशत्रु) (1st), **Kalashoka** (2nd), **Ashoka** (3rd), **Kanishka** (4th).

Monuments and religion

- Kanishka builds a great stupa at **Peshawar**. Chinese pilgrims later describe it as a wonder.
- His coins show **Buddha**, **Shiva (Oesho)**, **Mithra / Miiro**, and Greek deities on the same monetary series. That mirrors Kushan religious eclecticism.
- Kanishka is a common **trap option** for **Hathigumpha**. That inscription belongs to **Kharavela** (खारवेल) of Kalinga — not Ashoka, Harsha, or Kanishka.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q23

With reference to the invaders in Ancient India, which one of the following is the correct chronological order?

A. Greeks — Sakas — Kushans B. Greeks — Kushans — Sakas C. Sakas — Greeks — Kushans D. Sakas — Kushans — Greeks

Show answer

Logic: Stem tests relative order of the three Hellenistic / Central Asian waves; trap B flips Sakas and Kushans. **Ans: A** — Greeks before Sakas before Kushans. Kanishka's Kushans are the last of the three.

> **Logic:** Shaka era **78 CE** is not Vikrama **57 BCE**. Kanishka is not Kharavela. Fourth council is Kanishka's fact, not Ashoka's.

6.11 Dress, Sculpture, and Iconography under the Foreign Waves

Clothes of the invaders | Gandhara vs Mathura | early Shiva | Nataraja trap

Royal and divine dress

- Indo-Greeks keep Hellenistic royal portrait dress on coins — cuirass, diadem, Greek deities such as Athena — while adopting Indian scripts and some Indian gods.
- **Shakas** and **Kushans** bring Central Asian horse-nomad kit into Indian royal art: long coat / caftan, **trousers**, belt, and boots.
- **Kanishka's Mat statue** is the clearest sculpture fact for that look. Vima's enthroned Mat type wears the same heavy steppe garments.
- North Indian **Surya** often appears in **udichya-vesa** — tunic, trousers, and boots — under Shaka-Kushan / Iranian solar influence. Southern Surya images usually stay bare-legged. Do not treat booted Surya as a Chola bronze fact.

Two art schools

School	Zone	Stone	Look
Gandhara	NW (Peshawar–Taxila–Afghan belt)	Grey / green **schist** (also stucco)	Greco-Roman Buddha face, wavy hair, heavy drapery
Mathura	**Uttar Pradesh** (उत्तर प्रदेश)	Mottled **red sandstone**	Indigenous body types, yaksha heritage, smiling / robust figures

- Both schools make early human **Buddha** images in the Kushan age. Gandhara leans Hellenistic. Mathura leans Indian.
- Mathura also carves Jain tirthankaras, yaksha–yakshi railings, and early Hindu gods.
- **Amaravati** (अमरावती) limestone narrative art is Satavahana Andhra — not a NW foreign school. Keep it out of this chapter's invader pair.

Early Shiva — and why Nataraja does not belong here

- Kushan Mathura shows early anthropomorphic **Shiva** as **linga**, **mukhalinga** (one-faced / four-faced), and standing forms with Nandi.
- Kushan coins name the same deity as **Oesho** (Shiva), often with the bull.
- Composite early forms such as **Ardhanarishvara** also appear in this Mathura horizon.
- The classic **Nataraja** — Shiva as cosmic dancer with **damaru**, fire, **abhaya** (अभय), **gajahasta**, right foot on **Apasmara**, inside a **prabhamandala** (प्रभामंडल) — is a later **Chola** (चोल) lost-wax bronze type from Tamil Nadu.
- Early dancing-Shiva reliefs belong mainly to the **Gupta and post-Gupta** temple world (and later caves), **not** to Alexander, Menander, or Kanishka's Mat portrait.
- Trap sentence: foreign-invasion art = Gandhara / Mathura / booted Surya / early Shiva linga. It is **not** Chola Nataraja.

> **Logic:** Trousers + boots = Kushan / Shaka royal look. Red sandstone Buddha = Mathura. Grey schist Buddha = Gandhara. Nataraja = Chola, not Kushan.

UP Focus

Alexander's line stops at the **Beas**. **No** Macedonian campaign in Awadh, Kashi, or Magadha. Indo-Greek political centre = **Taxila / Sagala**, not Mathura. **Mathura** and the middle Ganga foreign layer are mainly **Kushan** — second capital, red-sandstone art school, and the **Mat** royal statues in Central Asian coat–trousers–boots dress. Heliodorus pillar = **Besnagar, MP**, not UP. Rudradaman's Junagadh rock is Gujarat, not UP — but the Sudarshana-lake Mauryan layer is a cross-state key fact. Classic **Nataraja** is Chola Tamil bronze, not a Mathura-Kushan sculpture.